Annotated Model Essay • The Alchemist

Revised classroom model • Essay at left; numbered notes explain writerly moves at right.

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Please Stop Improving My Life

The crystal merchant's first mistake was hiring someone with potential.[1] In Paulo Coelho's *The Alchemist*, Santiago arrives at his shop and begins making improvements. A display case attracts customers; tea served in crystal glasses gives thirsty visitors another reason to buy. Soon the business is growing. This is usually the point at which an inspirational speaker invites us to applaud. I would like to ask the shopkeeper whether he wanted a larger shop. We are too quick to call people cowardly when they decline the more ambitious lives we have helpfully designed for them. A life can grow deeper without growing bigger.[2]

The merchant says his shop is "exactly the size I always wanted it to be" (Coelho, pt. 2).[3] That little word *exactly* suggests a target reached, rather than an ambition abandoned. A person who orders one bowl of noodles is not necessarily failing to order six. Sometimes the correct amount is the amount you wanted. We accept this principle at lunch and become suspicious when someone applies it to a career. A larger business may offer valuable opportunities. It may also absorb the evenings, friendships, and small pleasures that made its owner's life worth financing.

G. K. Chesterton supplies a useful embarrassment. In "A Piece of Chalk," he describes going out to draw and discovering that he has forgotten his white chalk. He worries about finding an artist's shop. Then he realises that he is sitting on a landscape made of chalk, breaks off a piece, and continues drawing. The supplies department was underneath him.[4] His difficulty was real; his account of it was incomplete. He had imagined himself short of something because he had stopped noticing what surrounded him. Before obtaining more, we might inspect what familiarity has made invisible.[5]

Attention also needs somewhere to settle. Chesterton argues that "the essence of every picture is the frame" (*Orthodoxy*, ch. 3).[6] A frame excludes almost the entire universe so that we can look properly at one piece of it. Choosing a life involves similar exclusions. Practising the violin means spending an hour in which we do not practise the cello, learn Korean, or establish a promising small empire. Nobody accuses a violinist of wasting the afternoon's cello potential. Yet we sometimes discuss young people as if every unused possibility were an unpaid debt. Commitment allows a possibility to become something more substantial than a possibility.

[1] Comic reversal. I make a desirable quality sound dangerous. The joke introduces the essay's challenge to automatic admiration for ambition.

[2] State a contestable distinction. I distinguish depth from size after a concrete scene. This gives the essay a claim to investigate, rather than a topic to describe.

[3] Read one word closely. I explain what "exactly" implies, then test the idea with lunch. The familiar comparison makes the abstract distinction between sufficiency and failure visible.

[4] Make an anecdote earn its place. I compress Chesterton's episode to the overlooked resource and comic discovery. The scene embodies the problem instead of merely decorating it.

[5] Explain without overclaiming. I draw a limited inference about attention. One overlooked resource does not prove that every shortage is imaginary.

[6] Extend a metaphor. I move from Chesterton's picture frame to a hypothetical musician. The application is my argument: choosing boundaries can make sustained achievement possible.

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Nor does commitment condemn us to dullness. Chesterton observes children asking for the same enjoyable game again, then proposes that adults lack the strength to "exult in monotony" (*Orthodoxy*, ch. 4).[7] To exult is to rejoice intensely. The provocation belongs to his larger theological account of a creator delighting in repeated creation. Its human challenge is immediate: perhaps we demand novelty because our attention gives out before the world's interest does. Consider rereading a favourite novel. The sentences remain where we left them; we discover something new because we have become better readers. Returning can be an accomplishment.[8]

Unfortunately, this is where my defence of the crystal merchant encounters the crystal merchant. His crystals are "mute," and his daily café is "horrible" (Coelho, pt. 2).[9] Those words offer little evidence of delight. He preserves his dream of pilgrimage partly because fulfilling it might disappoint him; the imagined journey helps him endure the days he dislikes. Chesterton's child wants another turn because the game is wonderful. The merchant keeps the game going because he fears what might follow it. Although staying can express devotion to a good life, it can also protect us from testing a bad one.[10] The same decision can serve opposite purposes.

The answer is to examine what our limits protect. Do they preserve something we actively value, or merely keep an uncomfortable question out? Contentment requires work. Chesterton makes this point elsewhere through a white post: keeping it white means repainting it (*Orthodoxy*, ch. 7).[11] A lasting friendship needs calls returned, disagreements faced, apologies made. None of these activities increases the number of friends on a list. All can enlarge the friendship. There is a demanding form of ambition in learning to care for something well. The merchant's refusal becomes troubling when it shelters resignation rather than that kind of care.

Santiago deserves credit for making possibilities visible. His employer deserves the chance to decide which ones are worth pursuing. Imagine a student who draws beautifully: one adult suggests selling the drawings, another recommends competitions, and a third proposes an account with a regular posting schedule. Within minutes, a pleasurable afternoon has acquired a marketing department.[12] Perhaps the student wants all this. Perhaps she wants to become an excellent artist while keeping Sunday afternoon her own. We should help her discover the difference. Talent creates possibilities; it does not appoint every admiring adult as a manager.

[7] Give a quotation its context. I explain the children's game and acknowledge the theological argument, so the phrase does not become a free-floating slogan.

[8] Develop through an accessible example. Rereading shows how unchanged material can yield a changed experience. It gives the reader a concrete test of the claim about repetition.

[9] Let evidence challenge the argument. I introduce the strongest difficulty for my defence and analyse the merchant's language. His dissatisfaction prevents me from equating staying with wisdom.

[10] Sentence pattern to imitate. "Although [action] can express [worthy motive], it can also [troubling alternative]." Repeating "can" gives both readings room while qualifying the initial claim.

[11] Introduce a constructive alternative. The post leads to the work of friendship. Maintenance becomes a demanding third possibility alongside expansion and stagnation, answering the objection rather than dismissing it.

[12] Apply the argument through humour. I label the student scene as imagined and let the advice escalate. The joke exposes how encouragement can quietly become an obligation, while allowing the student to choose ambition.

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Before improving someone's life, then, ask what the improvement would help that person attend to—and what it would make harder to keep. The question applies equally to a new venture and an old excuse.[13] The merchant may need to leave his shop; another person may need to close the laptop and inhabit the evening already available. Chesterton eventually found his chalk, but the discovery did not leave him doing nothing. He began drawing again. That is the promise of enough: having found something worth our attention, we can finally get on with giving it.[14]

WORKS CITED

Coelho, Paulo. *The Alchemist*. Translated by Alan R. Clarke, 25th-anniversary ed., HarperOne, 2015 e-book. Part Two, crystal-merchant episode.

Chesterton, G. K. "A Piece of Chalk." 1905. Society of G. K. Chesterton.

Chesterton, G. K. *Orthodoxy*. 1908. Chs. 3, 4, and 7. Project Gutenberg, e-book 130.

[13] Bring the opposing cases together. I apply one question to both expansion and avoidance. The conclusion preserves the complication rather than simply returning to the opening position.

[14] Return to an image with a new implication. I return to the chalk, now stressing the drawing it enables. Enough becomes the beginning of purposeful activity rather than an excuse to stop.

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